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Title:
## Going Down

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SCENE I

**High-Rise Apartment—24th Floor Hallway.**

*(Bare and anodyne, like a hotel hallway. Two main elevators sit in a central alcove.)*

MARAH, CASSIDY, HELEN.

*(MARAH (31), brisk walk that won't help her escape herself, emerges from her apartment in scrubs. A moment later, at the opposite end of the hall, CASSIDY (33), confident she has a point, but usually does, emerges from her own apartment in athletic gear. The women sigh when they lay eyes on each other, before beginning the awkward walk to their same destination: the elevators. Cassidy hits the elevator button first. Marah stares at her a long beat before…)*

CASSIDY. *(Overly pleasant.)* Good Morning, Marah!

MARAH. *(Mumbled.)* G'Morn, Cass.

CASSIDY. Sorry?

MARAH. Oh, I was mumbling. See, I didn't get the best night's sleep—

CASSIDY. *(After a guttural moan.)* Starting early today!

MARAH. –because, not sure if you knew, but your party was <u>loud</u>. Verging on cacophonic.

CASSIDY. What does "cacophonic" mean?

MARAH. <u>Reprehensibly</u> loud.

CASSIDY. What does "reprehensibly" mean? *(Before Marah starts.)* Doesn't matter. That's why I left a bottle of wine outside your door, to apologize for the noise—

MARAH. A bottle of wine that I broke…while opening my door to complain about said nose.

CASSIDY. You do have an aggressive door swing.

MARAH. I do not! I open doors gently, and compassionately.

CASSIDY. Mmhmm.

MARAH. Look, Cassidy, I don't know if you know, but I'm a surgeon at UChicago Medicine—

CASSIDY. I did not know. Tell me a tenth time.

MARAH. –and as a result, I kind of need sleep, so I don't amputate the wrong arm by mistake. I'd get <u>sued</u> for that. I doubt you'd get sued for, what… serving the wrong wine vintage?

CASSIDY. Okay, a) not a bartender, b) I still know my vintages.

MARAH. If that's true, why did you leave me a bottle of skunk wine?

CASSIDY. *(Realizing it's not worth it.)* I'll be quieter next time.

MARAH. Good. Because I'm getting up early to **cut people open**, while you're getting up early to…get swoll?

CASSIDY. Nice. Turning fitness into a weakness.

MARAH. Anywho! I'm glad we could reach an understanding about the noise.

CASSIDY. Yeah. Sure. But just so you know: my work matters too.

MARAH. Oh, you're one *those*? "All work matters?"

CASSIDY. *(Rolls her eyes and presses the elevator button again.)* Where is the…

*(From around the corner strolls HELEN (71), small stature, immovable presence, holding a piece of paper. She slaps it onto the elevator door.)*

HELEN. Morning, ladies.

CASSIDY. *(Overly pleasant.)* Well, if it isn't the best landlady I've ever met, Helen—

HELEN. No one complained last night.

CASSIDY. *(Dropping the act.)* Phew.

MARAH. Excuse me! I most certainly complained.

HELEN. You did? Huh. Were you doing that high-pitched fisherman's wife scream you do? At my age, I can't hear that frequency anymore.

MARAH. *(Extremely high-pitched.)* I do not do a fisherman's wife scream—

HELEN. *(With a shrug.)* Yep. Dog whistle.

*(In a huff, Marah steps past Helen to reads the sign on the elevator.)*

MARAH. "Out of order!" Helen. We're on the 24th floor? How can the elevator be out of order!?

HELEN. Well, now, it all started 20 years ago, when a young witch, eager to enact her first curse… *(Off Marah's intent listening.)* It's a machine! It broke down.

MARAH. Well, when's it going to be fixed? I have to go to work. I cut people for a living!

HELEN. I still do that from time to time. *(Darkly.)* When they owe me. *(Jovial.)* I'm just joking. I'm a landlady, not a mob boss! *(Darkly.)* Until you cross me.

CASSIDY. *(Overly pleasant.)* FYI: I'm up to date on rent!

HELEN. Oh, I know! *(Darkly.)* I always know. *(Whistles and starts off.)*

MARAH. Helen, stop! How am I going to get downstairs?

HELEN. Well, now, let's see. I could drill a hole in this floor, then drill a hole in that floor, and so on and so on, buy you a parachute, and then— *(Off Marah's intent listening.)* Walk, you loon! Geez. And you're a doctor? No wonder cancer hasn't been cured. *(She disappears.)*

MARAH. Helen. Helen! UGH. How am I supposed to walk down 24 flights of stairs? I can't sweat before work. The gloves and mask will slip off my body, and then I'll get sick and die! *(Extremely high-pitched.)* I just don't understand how she could do this to—

CASSIDY. *(Covering her ears.)* Mmhmm.

MARAH. *(Huffs for a minute, before calming down.)* I guess we're walking. You want to go first, get a head start?

CASSIDY. Why?

MARAH. So we don't have to walk together.

CASSIDY. Oh, grow up. We both have places to be. Let's just go. *(Opens the stairwell door.)*

MARAH. *(Seeing Cassidy holding the door, grudgingly walks through it.)* Thanks. But you didn't have to do that. There's no word for **female** chivalry.

CASSIDY. There is. It's called **sexism.**

SCENE II

**High-Rise Apartment—24th Floor Stairwell.**

*(In sharp contrast to the hallway: dingy and musty.)*

MARAH, CASSIDY, RAINY, ABNER.

*(Marah is a few steps ahead of Cassidy as they begin their trek down the stairs together.)*

MARAH. UGH. It's only been one floor, and I'm already exhausted.

CASSIDY. Stop talking. Saves breath.

MARAH. You must be having fun. You wanted to get in a workout.

CASSIDY. *(Sarcastic.)* Yeah. I'm having a blast.

MARAH. Why wouldn't you be? Exercise by day, party by night, unclear on your afternoons…

CASSIDY. Marah. Last night wasn't a party. I was hosting a—

*(The door bursts open and out flies RAINY (23), sweet little face, aggressively friendly.)*

RAINY. Cass! OMG, so glad I found you. Last night was **so** fun! I got way, *way* too drunk.

*(Marah gives a smug look to Cassidy.)*

CASSIDY. Again. It was not a party. It was a <u>function</u>.

RAINY. Emphasis on FUN! Not on CTION.

MARAH. What would that even mean?

RAINY. IDK! I find English is less something you *know* and more something you *feel*, yeah?

MARAH. No, that's not right.

RAINY. But do you *know* that? Or do you *feel* that? *(With Marah stunned silent, Rainy pivots to Cassidy.)* So, Cass: that red wine you served was delish.

CASSIDY. Glad you liked it.

MARAH. Do you have any food leftover?

CASSIDY. I don't.

MARAH. Boo! I would've loved some. Those appetizers, they were **too** good, and I am **too** short on rent this month, so free food is literally keeping me alive RN. Completely literally, as in, like, I would die without it!

CASSIDY. That's concerning. I could…have you over for dinner?

RAINY. You so don't have to…but thank God! I'm lucky to live near you. Your parties are just the best! And you throw so many: parties at your apartment, parties on the rooftop, parties in the sub-basement. Boy, that was a weird one. K, let me know what time for dinner, bye! *(She goes.)*

MARAH. I just pretend to be asleep when she knocks.

CASSIDY. Guess that's why she's my friend, and you're not.

MARAH. *(A bit hurt.)* Yeah. No, we're not. I mean, I've never had a female friend. So… *(Hustles ahead of Cassidy down the stairs.)*

CASSIDY. *(Standing still, sighs and calls after Marah.)* Look. I'm not some dumb party girl. *(She watches Marah slow, but not stop.)* I'm the executive director for a charity.

MARAH. What type of charity?

CASSIDY. The type that donates to tumor operations and research.

MARAH. Really!

CASSIDY. Yes. It's called "Tumor Has It." All proceeds go to local hospitals. That party you heard on the roof last night was a fundraiser. So, in a way, the reason you have work at *all* this morning, working with tumors…is thanks to me. *(Sarcastic.)* Wait. What do you do again?

MARAH. Actually, I don't usually do tumors. The fratty doctors in the OR won't let me.

CASSIDY. Wait. They can do that?

MARAH. I'm the youngest one there, and the only woman, so…yeah. They get all the fun stuff – hearts, brains, and for some reason, boobs – while I'm stuck taking out things like moles, and tonsils, and appendixes.

CASSIDY. So, your job is removing things from people…that could just as easily stay inside those people.

MARAH. That is a rudely-worded but mostly-accurate version of my life, yes. You figured it out! I don't matter to anyone. *(Sighs and leans against the railing. Almost seems like she'll cry.)*

*(Cassidy catches up at last. Before she can say anything reassuring, a man steps out from his floor and walks up to them: ABNER (65), jolly, white hair, will never end the conversation first.)*

ABNER. Dr. Marah! Did you know the elevator's out?

MARAH. *(Wiping sweat from her forehead.)* Yes, Abner, I did.

ABNER. But the good news is: I ran into you! I've been meaning to talk to you, because I'm having a bit of a medical problem. And see, with me being a bachelor and all, it's not every day I have someone to check suspicious bumps or bruises on my body, not to mention unusual odors—

MARAH. Abner, I kind of have to get to work. I don't think I can—

ABNER. Now, I know you don't like it when people show you stuff on their bodies—

MARAH. Thank you.

ABNER. So I'm just going to describe it to you in detail. There's this round, shall we say... pustule on my stomach. When I touch it, it jiggles, like there's some sort of fluid in it. And when I bend over and put my ear next to it, I sort of can hear the ocean. Also, it's a green color. Let's call it a…rotting leaf. So. What do you think it is?

MARAH. I can't know without looking at it. *(Before he can respond.)* I'm not looking at it.

ABNER. I understand. No such thing as a free lunch. But we're both here. And I'm more than happy to barter. So. You need your taxes done? I'm a CPA.

MARAH. No, Abner, I don't—

ABNER. Oh, you've been cheating Uncle Sam. That's okay. I can be creative. One time, I said a woman had 5 dependents. Know what they were? Nutcrackers. That she named. And sponge-bathed. *(After an awkwardly long silence.)* They were named after her dead Dalmatians—

MARAH. Okay, just show me!

*(Abner lifts up his shirt. The cyst is as gross as described. Marah makes a face before measuring its proportions with her fingers and staring closely. Cassidy watches the exam with fascination.)*

MARAH. Looks benign. But you need to get it removed before you feel any abdominal pain.

ABNER. Thank you, Dr. Marah! Your exemptions for being a single Mom WINK and home-owner WINK WINK are as good as filed! *(He skips off happily.)*

*(Once he's out of sight, Marah shakes her head and laughs. Cassidy walks over and puts a hand on Marah's shoulder.)*

CASSIDY. Hey. Seems like you mattered to him.

MARAH. That cyst wasn't going to kill him. Just make him even more unappealing.

CASSIDY. If I can give you some advice? Woman-to-woman? You're letting the guys at work get inside your head. Don't. You're clearly a capable doctor. Even for a woman. I'm kidding. No qualification needed.

MARAH. *(Smiles, before checking her watch.)* I'm even more capable when I'm actually at the office, so…I should get a move on.

CASSIDY. *(Thinking.)* You know, it's been a few minutes. Should we see if the elevator works?

MARAH. Not on this floor! Abner might show me his feet next.

CASSIDY. Fine, let's get off here. *(Cassidy holds open the door for Marah, who's reluctant to go first.)* Yes, yes. Sexism. We did this already. Go! *(Cassidy walks out after Marah.)*

SCENE III

**High-Rise Apartment—16th Floor Hallway.**

*(Visibly dirtier than Marah and Cassidy's floor. Both elevators bear an "Out of Order" sign.)*

MARAH, CASSIDY, ERIK.

*(Marah strides up to the elevator and groans when she sees the "Out of Order" sign.)*

MARAH. No! This is not my day.

*(Marah and Cassidy cry out in surprise as ERIK (45), has all the manic energy of a man on the run, pops up from out of nowhere.)*

ERIK. 'Sup, ladies. I'm dating a woman who lives on this floor. Alice. You know her?

MARAH. No. Not all women know each other.

ERIK. I know…there's no such thing as female geography. Or female anatomy.

MARAH. No, that's not right.

ERIK. How would you know?

CASSIDY. You mean besides not being an idiot.

MARAH. I'm a doctor.

ERIK. Nuh-uh!

CASSIDY. …Yes?

ERIK. Okay, prove it.

MARAH. Prove to you that I'm a doctor?

ERIK. Yeah. Do that.

MARAH. *(Assessing.)* Your cranial circumference is below average. Suggests below average IQ.

ERIK. Whoa! You are a doctor. Righteous. So, I have a question about Alice—

MARAH. Again, whom we do not know.

ERIK. Look, I know you don't *know her* know her—

CASSIDY. Do you *know that* know that?

ERIK. But, as a woman who also lives in this building: what do you think she's thinking? She seems to like me, but she won't actually say it. You're both ladies. Help me figure this one out?

MARAH. While we are both female humans—

ERIK. Exactly!

CASSIDY. Honestly? I'm not the one to ask about this. I just got out of a relationship.

ERIK. *(Interest piqued.)* Oh?

CASSIDY. Not an invitation.

ERIK. *(Let down.)* Oh.

CASSIDY. And it was my fault things ended, so…yeah. Not the best person to speak for women.

MARAH. Also, asking one woman to speak for all women is insulting on its face, but…you know. *(She looks away from Erik, who indeed looks confused.)* Cass, how was it your fault?

CASSIDY. *(After a heavy sigh.)* I spent way, *way* too much time…at work.

MARAH. …at your charity. So, in other words: you were *too* good a person.

CASSIDY. I didn't put it that way on purpose…

MARAH. UGH. I guess you're just always going to be better than me. Even when you get dumped, you make it work!

ERIK. *(Titillated.)* Amen, sister.

*(Marah takes off downstairs alone. Cassidy moves to follow her, when Erik puts his hand out.)*

ERIK. Hey. It's a long walk downstairs…and only a short walk to Alice's.

*(Cassidy, creeped beyond belief, leaves the floor without saying another word.)*

## SCENE IV

**High-Rise Apartment—16th Floor Stairwell.**

*(Cleaner and cleaner the further down they descend.)*

MARAH, CASSIDY.

*(Marah starts off a full staircase ahead of Cassidy. Cassidy hurries to catch up to her, almost falling a few times in her haste, but consistently managing to right herself.)*

CASSIDY. Marah! *(Near-fall.)* Wait. *(And another.)* Marah! *(Finally catches up to Marah.)*

MARAH. UGH. And you're graceful? Why do I even exist!?

CASSIDY. Stop. Do you really feel this competitive with me just because I'm a woman?

MARAH. You first!

CASSIDY. What?

MARAH. Every opportunity you get, you find a subtle way to one-up me. *(Imitating Cassidy.)* I'm Cassidy. I work for a charity. I got broken up with for being a good person. I'm a D-Cup.

CASSIDY. I never said I was a D-Cup.

MARAH. Am I wrong? *(Ashamed, Cassidy shakes her head no.)* See? You're obviously just as insecure as me. But you express it through…extraordinary confidence. It's very confusing! You're like, a puzzle…wrapped in a bitch!!!

CASSIDY. I'm not some…bitch puzzle. But okay. Fine. I am…a bit insecure around you.

MARAH. *(Genuinely surprised.)* You are? I was just saying that to try to win the argument.

CASSIDY. Yes. You, well, all doctors…make me feel that way. I tried to get into med school… several times. After my Dad got a brain tumor, I applied…wrote a heartfelt essay that clearly did not land with the admissions board…but once I started working in charity, I realized I could help another way. I do really great work. But sometimes, I still can't help but feel…I let him down.

MARAH. You didn't. *(Stepping closer to Cassidy.)* And thank you, for being so vulnerable. *(After an awkward pause.)* So…should we kiss?

CASSIDY. What? No. Why would you think I was angling for that?

MARAH. Sorry! I'm not great with social cues. One of my *many* flaws, apparently!

## SCENE IV

**High-Rise Apartment—1st Floor Lobby.**

*(Shockingly well-maintained considering how every other part of this building has looked.)*

MARAH, CASSIDY, RAINY, ABNER, ERIK, HELEN.

*(Marah and Cassidy stagger out of the stairwell, sweaty and bedraggled. They stand out in the otherwise pristine lobby.)*

MARAH. I'm never walking that much again. If the building's on fire, I'll just jump, and pray.

CASSIDY. Can you prescribe prayer?

MARAH. In very low doses.

*(An elevator door DINGS. Marah and Cassidy look up in shock. They stand before the elevators, as out walk Rainy and Abner.)*

CASSIDY. *(To Marah.)* What the—they took the elevator!

RAINY. Oh, hey Cass! Weird coinc: I was just talking about you with *(re: Abner)* him!

ABNER. Hello again, ladies.

RAINY. He told me your friend is a doctor? Which is **such** a coincidence, because LOL, I have, like, **zero** health insurance!

MARAH. Then I probably couldn't see you as a patient.

RAINY. Even if I said pretty please? And if I don't get a physical, I'll die? Completely literally, like, I would die without it!

ABNER. Have a heart, Dr. Marah. Help her out like you did me? I'll do your friend's taxes too, if it helps.

MARAH. Why would I trade my labor for her benefit?

RAINY. Friendship!

CASSIDY. Sounds more like exploitation.

RAINY. Right. Friendship!

ABNER. Help her, Dr. Marah. She's too young to die. *(Wistful.)* Like I once was…

*(DING. Erik emerges from the other elevator. He makes a beeline for Rainy.)*

ERIK. Ooh, another lady! Say, do you know Alice? Lives in your building, is a woman? I can—

MARAH AND CASSIDY. Everyone, shut up!!! *(The room goes silent. They look at each other, impressed by the power of their unity.)*

MARAH. No, actually, un-shut up.

CASSIDY. When did the elevator start working?

*(Helen emerges triumphantly through the front doors.)*

HELEN. About two minutes after I saw you.

MARAH. Helen! We just walked down 24 flights of stairs because we thought it was broken. Why didn't you come tell us it was fixed?

HELEN. Well, now, gee, I sent out the homing signal, and when that didn't work, I summoned a flock of pigeons to spread word that— *(Off Marah's intent listening.)* You were gone already! How was I supposed to know where you went? I don't track my tenants. *(Darkly.)* Anymore.

CASSIDY. So. Does that mean everything in the building is working again?

HELEN. Well…not exactly. In turning the elevators back on, I may, *may* have accidentally knocked out the heat. So…you guys might want to find people to bundle up with for warmth.

*(Rainy and Erik look at each other, shrug, and walk out the front door, arm-in-arm. Rainy considers Abner only a moment. Seeing he's alone, he sighs, and rides the elevator back up.)*

HELEN. And I'm guessing you two ladies won't want to be roommates, given your *(re: Marah)* many previous complaints about *(re: Cassidy)* this one.

MARAH. I thought you said you couldn't hear my fish-voice!

HELEN. I'm talking about the thousand written complaints.

MARAH. *(Registering Cassidy's surprise.)* I don't recall writing that many complaints…

HELEN. Oh, you sure did. About the parties. The noise. Your loneliness. Your jealousy. Plus, your confusing attraction to—

MARAH. Okay, thanks, Helen! We'll figure something out without your help! As always!

HELEN. Hey, what's a landlady for, if not to make money off her land, and…that's it. *(She whistles her way into the elevator. It doesn't go up right away.)* Someone should really fix these door close buttons. Oh wait, that'd be me. Eh, I can live with it. *(The doors finally close.)*

CASSIDY. *(To Marah.)* Quite the list of complaints.

MARAH. I'm sorry! It was before I really knew you.

CASSIDY. And you think after 24 flights of stairs, you really know me?

MARAH. Better than before! I used to think you were a puzzle wrapped in a bitch. Now, I know: you're a bitch wrapped in a puzzle.

CASSIDY. *(With a smirk.)* Is that your way of asking to be roommies till the heat's back on?

MARAH. Come over. We can have a slumber party! A **quiet** slumber party.

CASSIDY. Yeah. We *could* stay at your place. *Or*. We could stay at mine. Since it's so much bigger than—

MARAH. Yeah, you remember that topping thing, you weren't going to do anymore?

CASSIDY. Sorry. Habit. *(Beat.)* I'm not wrong.

MARAH. Okay, well, thank you. I'd love to stay over at my new *friend's* place. *(As Cassidy smiles and presses the elevator button, Marah looks over at her.)* So…should we kiss?

CASSIDY. What? No. Why do you keep thinking that?

MARAH. Social cues. Learning them!

*(The elevator doesn't come right away.)*

CASSIDY. I think I might head back up, actually. Work out a little bit later. See you tonight?

MARAH. No. I'm calling in sick today. Maybe a day without me will make the OR bros realize how much they need me after all. Or they fire me, and I find a better job. Or a worse one.

CASSIDY. Those are all the possibilities.

MARAH. So, I'm heading back up with you! *(Beat.)* You, umm…want to take the stairs?

CASSIDY. *(With a smile.)* Definitely.

*THE END.*